“Strong emotions mean my faith is weak.”

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Where it often comes from

Being told as a child to stop crying or calm down. A church culture that valued always looking happy and peaceful. Hearing that a “real Christian” should never feel afraid, sad, or upset. A family where feelings were ignored or punished. Confusing strong feelings with a lack of trust in God.

What Scripture teaches

God made us with emotions, and Scripture is full of people of strong faith who felt deeply. The psalmists poured out sorrow, fear, and confusion to God. Jesus was deeply troubled and distressed in Gethsemane. Paul admitted to fears within. Faith does not mean having no strong feelings; it means bringing those feelings to God and trusting Him with them.

> *“Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge”* **(Psalm 62:8)**.

Also see

> “Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence” **(Psalm 42:5)**.

> “He took with Him Peter, James, and John, and began to be deeply troubled and distressed. Then He said to them, ‘My soul is consumed with sorrow to the point of death. Stay here and keep watch.’” **(Mark 14:33–34)**.

> “For when we arrived in Macedonia, our bodies had no rest, but we were pressed from every direction—conflicts on the outside, fears within. But God, who comforts the downcast, comforted us by the arrival of Titus” **(2 Corinthians 7:5–6)**.

> “When I am afraid, I put my trust in You” **(Psalm 56:3)**.

Common self-statements

- If I trusted God, I wouldn’t feel this way.
- Christians shouldn’t cry this much.
- My feelings prove I’m spiritually weak.
- I have to hide how I really feel.
- God is disappointed when I’m upset.
- Strong Christians are always calm.

Common logical errors

- **Emotional reasoning in reverse:** Concluding that strong feelings must mean weak faith.
- **Should statements:** “I should never feel afraid, sad, or angry.”
- **Labeling:** Calling yourself “weak” because you feel deeply.
- **Discounting the positive:** Overlooking that bringing feelings to God is an act of faith.
- **Comparison:** Comparing your inner life to other people’s calm appearance.

Challenging questions

- Did Jesus feel strong emotions? Was His faith weak?
- What did the psalmists do with their sorrow and fear?
- Does Psalm 62:8 tell me to hide my heart or pour it out?
- Who taught me that feelings were bad or dangerous?
- Can I feel afraid and still trust God at the same time?
- What would change if I saw my emotions as something to bring to God?
- Is faith about what I feel, or about whom I trust?

Truth summary

> Strong emotions do not mean my faith is weak. God made me with feelings, and Jesus Himself was deeply troubled. Faith is not the absence of strong feelings; it is bringing them honestly to God. I can pour out my heart to Him and trust Him at the same time.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anxiety/Worry
- Sorrow
- Trust
- Faith
- Peace

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Strong emotions mean my faith is weak"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Strong emotions mean my faith is weak." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did Jesus feel strong emotions?
- ☐ What did the psalmists do with their feelings?
- ☐ Does God tell me to hide my heart or pour it out?
- ☐ Who taught me feelings were bad?
- ☐ Can I feel afraid and still trust God?
- ☐ Is faith about feelings or about whom I trust?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Strong feelings do not mean weak faith.
- ☐ I can pour out my heart to God.
- ☐ Jesus Himself was deeply troubled, and He understands.
- ☐ I can feel afraid and still trust God.
- ☐ God comforts the downcast.
- ☐ Bringing my emotions to God is an act of faith.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 62:8**
  "Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge."
- [ ] **Psalm 42:5**
  "Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence."
- [ ] **Mark 14:33–34**
  "He took with Him Peter, James, and John, and began to be deeply troubled and distressed. Then He said to them, 'My soul is consumed with sorrow to the point of death. Stay here and keep watch.'"
- [ ] **2 Corinthians 7:5–6**
  "For when we arrived in Macedonia, our bodies had no rest, but we were pressed from every direction—conflicts on the outside, fears within. But God, who comforts the downcast, comforted us by the arrival of Titus."
- [ ] **Psalm 56:3**
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Feelings journal:** Each day, name one strong feeling I had and write a short prayer pouring it out to God.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 56:3 becomes: "When **Sarah** is afraid, **she** puts **her** trust in You."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Anxiety/Worry" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write your own psalm:** describe exactly how you feel, then end with one line of trust, like the psalmists did.
- ☐ **Tell one safe person how you really feel** this week, without minimizing it, and notice what happens.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 42 and 43 aloud,** noticing how the writer moves between despair and hope.
- ☐ **When a strong feeling comes, pause and name it,** then pray one sentence about it instead of pushing it away.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Strong emotions mean my faith is weak": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One feeling I brought to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Strong emotions mean my faith is weak.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for making me with feelings. Help me reject the lie that strong emotions mean my faith is weak. Teach me to pour out my heart to You, as the psalmists did and as Jesus did. When I am afraid or sad, help me put my trust in You. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.